

When Did Facts Become Negotiable?

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Essay

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Somewhere along the way, facts stopped being facts and started becoming suggestions. From missing Dr. Pepper to modern accountability, this is a look at why so many people seem determined to edit reality instead of living in it.

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A few weeks ago, my wife walked into the kitchen carrying an empty Dr. Pepper box with the kind of expression usually reserved for IRS audits and unexpected home repair estimates.

"Where did all the soda go?"

Now, for context, this wasn't the remains of some holiday gathering or family barbecue. This was a full case of Dr. Pepper. Twenty-four cans. We had bought it only a few days earlier. Somehow, through a process that would probably fascinate both physicists and insurance investigators, more than a dozen cans had vanished.

As any parent knows, this is where the mystery begins.

Children possess an extraordinary ability to forget events that directly involve them. Nobody ate the cookies. Nobody left the lights on. Nobody knows why the dog is suddenly afraid of the vacuum cleaner. Nobody touched the thermostat. Nobody moved the TV remote. Nobody has any explanation for anything. The moment responsibility enters a room, childhood memory loss becomes a legitimate medical condition.

My wife started asking questions. Predictably, nobody knew anything.

Then she walked into one of our kids' bedrooms and discovered what can only be described as the archaeological remains of a Dr. Pepper civilization. Empty cans were stacked under the bed like artifacts from a lost society. Not one or two. Not even five or six. There were enough cans under there to suggest a level of commitment that would have impressed a professional collector.

As she began pulling them out one by one, the evidence continued to grow. The pile got larger. The mystery got smaller. What happened next was my favorite part.

As each can emerged from beneath the bed, my child stared at them with complete bewilderment. It was the same expression I imagine a caveman would have if an archaeologist suddenly uncovered a Honda Civic buried in a glacier. There was confusion, concern, curiosity, and just a hint of existential dread.

The look seemed to say, "Well, that's certainly strange." The cans kept coming. The pile eventually occupied a portion of the bedroom floor. At that point, most rational observers would conclude the case had been solved. The evidence was sitting there in plain sight. The prosecution had photographs. The defense had nothing.

Then came the explanation. "I didn't drink those." To be fair, every parent has heard versions of this before. Children have been blaming siblings for things since the beginning of human history. Somewhere in the Old Testament there is probably a brother insisting someone else started it.

But the explanation continued. "My brothers put them there." Now the cans were literally sitting in the middle of the room after being pulled from under the bed. We weren't discussing an abstract theory. We weren't debating witness testimony. We weren't attempting to reconstruct a crime scene from fragmentary evidence. The evidence was physically present.

Yet somehow reality remained negotiable.

That moment stuck with me because it reminded me of something I've noticed more and more over the past several years. Kids may be the funniest examples, but they're hardly the only ones doing it. Does anyone live in reality anymore?

Not actual reality. Not what happened. Not what was said. Not what was done. Everybody seems to have their own custom version.

What's fascinating is how quickly it happens now. The sentence isn't even finished before the narrative begins changing. An event occurs and almost immediately a revised edition starts getting printed inside someone's head. Facts are reviewed. Certain details are removed. Other details are enhanced. Context is adjusted. Responsibility is redistributed.

A few minutes later, an entirely new version of events is available for public consumption. Kids do it because they're kids. Adults do it because we've gotten better at it. That's the uncomfortable part.

When I was growing up in the 1980s and 1990s, people certainly lied. People made excuses. People protected their egos. None of this is new. Human beings have been doing mental gymnastics since Adam blamed Eve and Eve blamed the snake. We've always had a talent for finding explanations that make us look a little better than we actually were.

The difference is that reality used to be harder to escape.

If you got caught doing something stupid, your friends remembered. Your parents remembered. Your neighbors remembered. There was usually enough shared memory floating around to keep your revised history from getting too far off track.

Trust me, there are plenty of things from my teenage years that I would prefer people forget.

I grew up during an era when young men somehow convinced themselves that oversized shirts, questionable hairstyles, and jeans with more missing fabric than what is holding them together represented sound decision-making. There are photographs from the early 1990s that should probably require special government clearance to view. There are fashion choices that deserve formal apologies.

But if someone pulled out the pictures today, I couldn't exactly claim my brother planted them. The evidence exists. Reality wins.

At some point, though, something shifted. We became a culture that treats reality less like a fixed thing and more like a customer satisfaction survey. If we don't like the results, we assume revisions are available.

You see it everywhere. You see it at work when deadlines are missed and suddenly a dozen explanations appear that somehow avoid the obvious answer. You see it online where entire arguments are reconstructed moments after they happen. You see it in politics, entertainment, social media, and everyday family life.

Five people can witness the same conversation. Video can exist. Screenshots can exist. Emails can exist. Text messages can exist. And somehow six completely different versions of events emerge by lunchtime. Part of me finds it funny because the process has become so predictable.

Someone says something foolish. Then they explain what they really meant. Then they explain what people should have understood. Then they explain why everyone else interpreted it incorrectly. Then they explain how they are actually the victim. By the end of the week, the original event has been buried beneath so many layers of explanation that nobody can find it anymore.

We've become a society of editors. Everyone is constantly revising. The thing I don't understand is why. What is so terrible about reality that we need to keep changing it? What is so unbearable about making a mistake? Why has being wrong become such a crisis?

I don't know anybody who enjoys admitting fault. I certainly don't. Nobody wakes up excited about discovering new personal flaws. Nobody hopes to spend an afternoon acknowledging bad decisions.

But being wrong used to be considered normal. You made mistakes. You learned from them. You moved on.

Somewhere along the line, we seem to have decided that mistakes are evidence of personal failure rather than evidence of being human. If every mistake becomes a threat to your identity, then of course you'll start editing reality. You have to. The alternative is admitting imperfection.

The irony is that this endless self-protection doesn't appear to be making anyone happier.

If constantly rewriting reality worked, we'd be the most emotionally healthy people in history. Instead, people seem anxious, defensive, and exhausted. Everyone is carrying around a public relations department inside their head, constantly managing perceptions and revising narratives.

That sounds tiring. Because here's the problem. Deep down, most people know.

Maybe not consciously. Maybe not every time. But somewhere beneath all the explanations and justifications, people generally know when they're lying to themselves. You know whether you drank the Dr. Pepper. You know whether you sent the email. You know whether you forgot the

appointment. You know whether you lost your temper. You know whether you made the mistake. Reality has a way of lingering in the background, quietly refusing to leave.

The more I think about it, the more I realize this isn't really a factual problem. It's a moral one. Accountability only works if reality matters. Forgiveness only works if reality matters. Growth only works if reality matters.

You can't learn from a mistake that never happened. You can't apologize for something you've convinced yourself wasn't your fault. You can't improve if every lesson gets rewritten before it reaches your conscience. That's why this matters. Not because people occasionally tell lies. That's as old as humanity itself.

What worries me is the growing belief that accountability itself is somehow harmful. We increasingly treat personal responsibility as if it's a form of cruelty. We act as though acknowledging mistakes will permanently damage our self-worth.

I don't think that's true. In fact, the strongest people I know tend to be the quickest to admit when they're wrong. Not because they're weak. Not because they enjoy it. Certainly not because they want consequences. They do it because they've learned something important. Being wrong isn't fatal. Being human isn't fatal. Making mistakes isn't fatal. The inability to admit mistakes, however, can wreck an entire life.

I've worked with people who could never admit fault. I've watched relationships struggle under the weight of constant excuses. I've seen organizations spend enormous amounts of time explaining problems rather than solving them.

It's amazing how much energy people spend avoiding a simple sentence. "I was wrong." Three words. That's it. Three words that can save friendships, marriages, careers, and family relationships. Three words that can end arguments. Three words that can stop the endless rewriting of history. Maybe that's what bothers me most about our current relationship with reality. We've lost confidence in our ability to survive the truth. We act as though admitting fault will somehow destroy us when, in reality, it usually does the opposite.

People trust honest people. People forgive honest people. People respect honest people. Nobody expects perfection. I don't expect perfection from my kids. God knows I don't expect perfection from myself.

What I want is honesty. I want the ability to look at a pile of evidence sitting in the middle of the floor and acknowledge what everyone can already see.

The older I get, the more I think that's one of the most underrated virtues in modern life. Just tell the truth. Not the polished version. Not the revised version. Not the version that protects your ego.

The actual version. The one that happened. Because reality isn't the enemy. Reality is where trust starts. It's where growth starts. It's where forgiveness starts. You can't build a decent life on a foundation of edited memories and rewritten stories.

Sooner or later, the cans end up on the floor. Sooner or later, the evidence appears. Sooner or later, reality shows up whether we invited it or not.

So if the majority of another case of Dr. Pepper mysteriously disappears from my house this summer, I already know how the investigation will begin. My wife will start asking questions. Nobody will know anything. A suspicious number of empty cans will eventually emerge from beneath a bed. There will likely be theories involving siblings, conspiracies, and perhaps supernatural intervention.

But I still hold out hope.

Maybe one day one of my kids will look at the evidence, shrug, and simply say, "Yeah, I drank them."

That would be a hell of a lot easier than inventing another universe.